

I think a lot of the discourse around AI's environmental and electricity concerns are examples of what I call "MEL syndrome"

Posted by u/Difficult-Ask683 • • 0 points • 6 comments

Miscellaneous electrical loads are the kind of thing that you see articles on every now and then, even from your electric company who you'd think would be knowledgeable about electricity.

You're often told that 10 percent of a family's electric usage comes from "a class of devices" that includes your cell phone and its charger. Or that using your ARM MacBook or even small TV less is just as good of a strategy to save power as not using your air conditioner so much. Maybe some parents will blame their high electric bills on a Nintendo Switch, not a hot Phoenix summer in a home almost entirely lit by incandescent light.

Yet many devices will use maybe a kilowatt hour or two a year. A phone might cost a dollar or so to charge a year, and efficient computer with two external monitors maybe 10 a month if it's a medium load on the efficient side, using California prices.

And leaving a modern MacBook or phone charger plugged in while idle will use maybe a tenth of a watt or less by my own measurements.

And these articles on how chargers are a significant load look at older statistics from 2005, when a laptop would drain a 100WH battery in a couple hours and a lot of ad adapters used simple transformers, which could use several watts when idle. Digital clocks on appliances were both more common and more energy intensive than they can be made now, and ARM was rarely used as much as it is now. Even then, an iPod Touch or Nintendo DS was a rounding error. You could pay your parents for the electricity to use it for a few months by finding a quarter on the ground.

Not to mention that a lot of these articles do calculations based on rated power, not measuring power and energy consumption, and put more emphasis on "using your electronics less" than other strategies really. You won't save much by reading a paper book in an air conditioned house under incandescent lights while using all your non-techie appliances as usual.

The "one watt initiative" has been all but fulfilled.

Yet the idea that a phone charger is a leaky faucet appears to be almost an old canard that assumes you are using an RC car charged by a simple transformer AC adapter that uses 10 watts just by being disconnected and takes 8 hours to charge for 1 hour of use.

This is how I feel about people using older AI models that require more power per token as the only way, as well as exaggerated claims about how every AI uses an IMMERSION COOLING system, as well as further slandering all forms of water cooling as though computers literally polluted just by running.

Oh, that video of the person with the hair straightener (click click) went viral while also clearly not understanding the difference between temperature and thermal energy when making it sound like even a laptop was a significant waste of power. That straight iron, if you used it just as much as a laptop, would use even more electricity. But both concentrate heat in a small area. My inefficient Intel i9 macbook emits the same thermal energy (BTU) as a PERSON. It feels hot on my lap, sure. But a soldering iron concentrates a fraction of the power of a space heater into heat energy in a little tip, hot enough to melt tin!

Comments

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[u/Kerrus](#) • 6 points • 2025-08-10 14:29 UTC

I mean antis insist that my air cooled desktop PC deletes water out of existence when it runs AI locally (and doesn't when I'm doing high intensity rendering that doesn't involve AI, somehow), so I think they're just reactionary nutjobs for the most part.

All the 'OMG ENERG USAGE' articles sure don't help though.

[u/erofamiliar](#) • 4 points • 2025-08-10 16:14 UTC

I think a lot of them honestly just don't know and don't care and are fine moving the goalposts. Oh, you generate things locally? Well, they aren't talking about `\*you\*`, their argument doesn't need to change in any way. Obviously when they say "AI", what they mean is "the subset of

generative AI that runs on corporate-funded datacenters, not to be confused with any other software or infrastructure that runs on datacenters because when that was an issue I didn't know or care, it's only AI that's now an issue because I personally take offense to it".

They don't need to explain themselves, the onus is on you to magically read their mind.

Also you're arguing in bad faith. /s

I generally think learning about the things you dislike is a good way to form arguments about them, but a lot of antis refuse. They hate the entire concept and so instead of their beliefs being informed by evidence, they cherry-pick evidence to suit their beliefs.